

'LEGACY FIRMS DON'T KNOW THE GAME HAS CHANGED'

Ola Founder Bhavish Aggarwal on competition from legacy firms, his e-mobility dream and future plans

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SINCE LAST FEBRUARY, when he announced his mega electric two-wheeler project, Ola Founder Bhavish Aggarwal has been in the news for both the right and wrong reasons. In an exclusive interview with *Business Today*, Aggarwal, 36, talks about electric cars, Ola's IPO plans and the incidents of fire. Edited excerpts:

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On online complaints:

We're a social-focussed brand. So it's logical that complaints will also come on social [media]. But our complaints are not anywhere out of the ordinary. It's just amplified more. We've tried to break the norm—that's why we're being targeted. Our model is unique in many ways. Not just the product, which is a huge disruptor in itself. There were electric two-wheelers made before us, but none of them were disruptive enough... Then the timeline in which we did it—we built that factory in seven months. The third piece is the go-to-market model. Consumers are used to a D2C model in other domains but not [in the] automotive [industry]... It's expected that the incumbents will feel a little uncomfortable with our approach. We started in December... In April and May we're much better off than December. Our goal is that [a] large majority of customer complaints should get solved in 24 hours... My prediction is that in a few years most automotive sales will be D2C. We're the first ones so we've [had] to face

PHOTO BY **BANDEEP SINGH**



ELECTRIC DREAMS Ola Founder and CEO Bhavish Aggarwal wants to build electric cars in the ₹10-30 lakh price bracket

the music of building the infrastructure, building the capabilities and also opening people's minds.

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On EVs catching fire:

There's been one such incident. Almost all manufacturers have gone through this... Our battery pack matches up to all industry standards in India, current and proposed. It matches up to European standards.

We have quality checks at every step. We tested our vehicles for millions of kilometres before we launched. [But] there will be these rare occurrences. It also happens with petrol vehicles. It's normalised in our society so we don't account for it. Data from other countries where EV penetration is much higher show that petrol vehicle fires are 10 times more than EV fires. We want to